



THE WARSAW SAGA

Definitions of SAGA

** Abbreviation for “Sexuality And Gender Acceptance”*

** Used to describe a narrative or story*

I came across an article that highlighted Poland as the worst country for LGBTQ+ individuals within the EU. It stuck with me, and I couldn't shake it off. While many European countries are progressing towards greater freedom and equality, Poland seems to be moving in the opposite direction.

Motivated by this, I decided to visit Warsaw and shine a light on the brave people who stay true to themselves despite the hatred around them. I named my project 'THE WARSAW SAGA,' a fitting title that stands for Sexuality And Gender Acceptance and embodies the stories I aim to tell.

Armed with my camera, I set out to create a photo series showcasing people who embrace their authenticity despite the hostility. Their portraits focus on self-expression, equality, and sexuality, emphasizing joy and liberation. The stories that accompany their portraits not only show the challenges they face, but also the resilience they draw from these challenges to effect change.

This project is dedicated to breaking down barriers and creating a future where everyone's SAGA is valued, one story at a time.

MY NAME IS SANDER DEKKER / ZINE 8

Photographs by Sander Dekker

A limited edition of forty copies with an original photo
and the music album "ÉCHO" by Madox.

This zine is copy number

*What if the siren song doesn't dull my senses, but it does
show me clearly better options.*

*Who should know that I really don't need hypnosis to
choose what's better*

and what's a deathtrap for your past life only.

*I would like to be a lonely siren in Capri - yes;
in my azure grotto, with dolphins, on a rock,
with my chosen, honest lover.*

*But I know that when I emerge from the sea waves,
the crowd in Capri can be buzzing and mean.*

*How to be a lonely siren in Capri, in a bug-infested resort?
What rock could I sit on then, to be a lonely siren in Capri?*

*This would be a life sentence or a deep-dive exile;
either a harpoon in the back or a traveling circus.
Math has screwed everything up.*

'The Village of the Sirens, 1942'

Poem written by Pat Dudek (Milkbaby)

For Foksal Gallery Foundation during 'Flesh and Blood Fairy Tales'

exhibition by X-Philes (1.12.2023–27.01.2024)



Warsaw coat of arms;

Polish syrenka (siren)



PAT

From a very young age, I started to dress differently - for the sake of my little distinct baby-contestation. As a teenager I was into subcultures like punk or emo. My experience with transition might be considered quite unique for a trans person. I didn't make any significant changes to my body, except for taking hormones, which honestly didn't change much. They made my boobs like they are, but my bone structure remained the same, and I didn't undergo any surgeries.

I don't feel like I belong to any specific community, especially within the LGBTQ+ sphere, which often feels narrow and artificial in Warsaw. I prefer living in a quiet village surrounded by forests, as I'm introverted and enjoy being alone. While I have LGBTQ+ friends, our connection isn't primarily based on our identities; they're just regular people I met, most of them artists. I feel like a free spirit, and as a spiritual person, with a body you don't have to feel gender as something really connected with your identity. Of course you can create identity as a performance, which I do. Often in collaboration with other artists.

– “I never feel ashamed or afraid of others, and I don't experience stage fright. This is the easiest part of my performance.”

When I was 18, in my high school period, I started working for a modeling agency because of my androgynous look, which was popular at the time. I was probably the only androgynous model comfortable with both male and female shoots on the local market. This experience allowed me to embrace both genders and feel absolutely genderless. Back then, terms like “non-binary” didn't really exist in the collective awareness; I just felt genderless, and I'm still comfortable with that term.

I never feel ashamed or afraid of others, and I don't experience stage fright. This is the easiest part of my performance. I sing excessively and loudly because I love the acrobatic quality of singing. Being connected with the audience is crucial for me. I might bite your ear or touch you—my performances are very interactive. What's fantastic about working with other artists is that they believe I'm unpredictable, pushing me to be myself in every performance. However, the most important thing to me as a performer is ▼







– “In this moment of my life, both personally and artistically, I believe that the most rebellious thing you can do, being me, is to go mainstream.”

quality. I hate trash and I don't accept mediocre performance. Neither mine nor anyone else's. Unlike some people who might hug the floor, twirl around, and call it performance, thinking they are Marina Abramovic or some new Viennese Actionist, I focus on singing as well as I possibly can, with strong emotion, aiming to evoke and control my audience with my voice. If I want to make them uncomfortable or terrified, I create a scary atmosphere with my voice, making it seem like something slimy is attacking them. But when I want to make them cry, I can do it successfully, but I have to work with my voice to make it as beautiful as possible.

The performances are challenging when you rely solely on your voice, and nothing else. The audience also ain't easy; they're often very prominent figures in the art space, critical, and even critics themselves. I've spent most of my young life around this demanding audience, but they demand something conscious, good, and truthful. After dealing with that for so long, I feel like the next step is: to be a pop star!

I know this isn't the typical motivation for wanting to be a pop star. You know, LGBTQ+ people can find safe spaces in the art world, often closed off, like galleries or museums. Sure, these spaces are public and everything, but this is also like announcing: “This space is LGBTQ+ friendly. Come in and see some exotic LGBTQ+ circus acts.” You can only find them there. They're not on the streets, not on the radio, not on TV, not in public situations. They're not accessible to everyone.

In this moment of my life, both personally and artistically, I believe that the most rebellious thing you can do, being me, is to go mainstream.



– “It’s pretty hard not to stand out because most Polish people often dress very basic, dull, simple and aren’t as fashion-conscious as someone like me, studying to become a fashion designer :)”

WIKTOR

You hear a lot of stories and see many comments on social channels like TikTok and Facebook that reveal what people really think. Most are very conservative, close-minded people. It’s pretty common to hear about aggressions when you look or act a bit different. People shouting things at you in public, physical aggression, or guys who got knifed just for being gay. And a few years ago, there was even a shooting at the Pride parades in Olsztyn. These risks are unfortunately always there when you’re out in public and stand out. And it’s pretty hard not to stand out because most Polish people often dress very basic, dull, simple and aren’t as fashion-conscious as someone like me, studying to become a fashion designer :)

In Warsaw, being a big city, there’s generally more acceptance than in other parts of Poland. But even here, there are areas that are safer or more dangerous. For everyday stuff, I usually dress more sober to avoid standing out. There are times, like when I go out for a night on the town, where I feel insecure about wearing makeup or dressing in a more feminine or unusual style. It can be challenging because these choices sometimes attract unwanted attention. ▼





– “One of my uncles is very close-minded. He doesn’t know much about me, but he knows I’m kind of a freak. Still, he sort of accepts me.”

I do love Warsaw. I was born here. I’ve always been a bit different, even as a kid. ‘That one’—the freak. But actually, I feel very lucky because whenever I’ve met people, I’ve never really heard any bad stuff about me. I mean, I might even have some friends with homophobic parents, but in some kind of strange way, they’ve always accepted me. For example, my grandma is very religious, but despite our differing values, she accepts me and is very loving toward me. In the photos of this zine, taken at her house, you can see a whole wall filled with my childhood pictures to prove that :) However, she always thinks that I’ll change my mind. It’s a bit hard for her to accept, maybe because she might just be living in her own world. She’s always asking if I’m having a girlfriend and when I will have a family. Even though I always tell her no. But she’ll never act unkindly towards me and I love her very much.

While my immediate family is very accepting, not all relatives share this sentiment. One of my uncles is very close-minded. He doesn’t know much about me, but he knows I’m kind of a freak. Still, he sort of accepts me. But

he’s also very religious and holds strong views against immigrants, LGBTQ+ people, and anything that doesn’t fit his idea of a Christian country. This is a big problem for many young people within their families who do not fit this idea. They are afraid of the reaction and therefore keep it a secret.

Despite all challenges, there are moments that warm my heart. Once, during a holiday, I heard something very nice from another uncle. He expressed his appreciation for me, acknowledging that it’s not easy to be different. He shared that when he was young, he was also very homophobic. He used to go to Plac Zbawiciela in Warsaw, which is a very gay-friendly area, to be aggressive and even violent towards LGBTQ+ people. However, he’s very regretful of his past actions, and he’s changed his mind. Now, he greatly admires me because I’m true to myself and unafraid. It was a really touching moment, knowing that people can truly change their minds. It makes me feel positive looking at the future! I think the mentality is slowly changing in a good way, but there’s still a lot to do.









ZOSIA

I think I started thinking about myself differently towards the end of secondary school. My body started to change and as a result, I was working out (a lot), chasing perfection. I started sexualizing myself when I was a bit older by sending half naked photos to my friends. I also learned what flirting was and began practicing it at parties. I liked that soooo much. I loved that attention, and honestly, I still do today. I was filling my classmates' galleries for years. While no one ever told me directly, I know what people thought about me: 'she's partying a lot, flirting a lot, dresses in a certain way, then for sure she's wild in bed and has a lot of sex.' And it was super funny for me, as at this point, I was still a virgin who had never been in a relationship.

Only then, at a certain point, it stopped being funny because I started to think, "Actually, why have I never been in a relationship? Is it because nobody wants to know the real me, just my body? Or am I not ready because I don't know who I want?"

Soon after my sister announced that she's bisexual, for the first time, I looked at my girlfriends differently. It was a weird feeling, and I was scared to talk about it with anyone, especially considering people in Poland are still very conservative, so I didn't. I thought that maybe it was just an impulse.

I think I kissed a girl for the first time when I was 17. She was my friend. Did I feel anything different after that? No. Since then, it was absolutely normal for me to kiss both sexes at parties without even thinking that maybe I have a different orientation. A breakthrough moment was when I almost had sex with one of my girlfriends. Then I started to think about that more seriously. Okay, I like girls and boys. So that makes me bisexual, right? Well, I don't like to call myself that because it doesn't feel this way. It just doesn't. In these times, it might look like it's easier to be yourself and be put into a certain group as people are more open to talk about it. But for me personally, it's still hard to understand myself. I still love showing my body, getting attention, and flirting. But lately, I think a lot about finding the right person who will accept me for who I am and support my decisions without judging. For me, that person could be anyone, regardless of gender.











MAD OX

I was born in Poland but moved to Paris when I was three. In France, you could be more free as a kid, with much more freedom of expression. Somewhere deep down, I sensed that something was a bit different with me, but as a kid, you don't understand the world, you don't overthink things. It all started being seen as something bad or weird when I came back to Poland at 8 years old.

It was the 'crazy 90s,' as we called them, and people were still figuring out how to live in a free country and not a communist one. Not everyone went with this new flow of the changes. France already had affordable, great-looking clothes back then, so I came back wearing fashionable stuff, and Poles were like, 'what the fuck is that boy wearing?' I've been called names, and on top of that, they were also malicious towards French people, calling me things like 'frog eater' and 'French faggot'. My life in Paris was different; I never had to hold myself back with my expression. I loved the Spice Girls, and my friends from class, whether they were boys or girls, loved them too. Same with ABBA and all those things that are considered 'gay'.

On top of that my grandma came from a very religious Catholic family. I was loving Sailor Moon, Spice Girls, Bravo magazine and she was like: 'This is diabolical, this is demonic, this is about the possessions and you're gonna get possessed'. That put a lot of trauma on me, because I was just a kid who was just doing things I liked.

Fortunately, I was strong and I didn't care that much about others, and my personality was kind of bubbly at the time. I mean, probably still is. Maybe a little bit less. I'm a little bit more dramatic and bitchy now [laugh]. But yeah, I was very bubbly. When someone was bullying me, I was okay with that, till a certain point. When somebody is crossing boundaries, I'm gonna fight back.

My grandmother did leave a fear in me, that's why I went to a Catholic gymnasium. I also joined an evangelizing group, which went to different cities every few months to spread Lord's word. During weekends, we stayed at schools and tried to help people find Jesus. I actually liked it very much, because there was a lot of singing and dancing. My first singing performance actually happened in a church when I was 4 back in Paris!







I didn't like all the rules they were imposing on me. You couldn't read Harry Potter for example. And I was like, 'the hell I can't'. I started bringing Harry Potter books to those prayer meetings at my school, showing them off and placing them in front of me when we were kneeling. I was really mad with others telling me what I should or shouldn't do. I was becoming pretty rebellious back then and I felt change was coming.

My sexual curiosity also started during the time I was in Catholic school. I couldn't fully face it yet, but since I was younger, I realized that male bodies turned me on a little bit more. In the beginning, I didn't get it. I was masturbating to erotic things, but when I saw a fully naked man for the first time, I was like WHOOOOO! It struck me differently. It was so much different, stronger. I was feeling guilty because everyone around me was saying shitty things about gays. So I wasn't ready to face the fact that I'm one too. Because of my background I had to confess about my thoughts. I felt weird about it because there was an old guy at the confessional booth listening to me talking about my childhood experiences of growing up and having sexual fantasies.

Even when I went for my first confession when I was eight years old, I had to mention that I was curious about private parts. They were teaching us that these thoughts are shameful, inappropriate and we should feel guilty about them. I think that's why I'm so rebellious against the church. I'm not against people who believe, but I'm against the teachings of the church. I think they are a bunch of hypocrites. I remember a time when I thought that I could confide in two of my close friends, so I told them that I'm bisexual, because I wasn't ready to admit that I'm gay. Both of them reacted negatively. They said it's a sin, they wouldn't accept that part of me, and that I should pray more. My reaction was simple: fuck this. I was done with people not accepting me for who I am for the first time in my life. They were supposed to be my friends, and I also had a bit of a crush on both of them, so that hurt me even more.

Since I went to high school, around 16 years old, with every passing month, I felt more freedom. It was a public school, one of the best in the region, and very artistic too. Many actors and musicians came from that school. By the time I was 18, I was fully aware of who I was. I started to experiment a lot with more androgynous looks in high school. Before that time I did have long hair, but I also had this weird, Catholic rocky style of wearing oversized clothes. I was leaning more towards being fashionable,







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wearing slim jeans, being sexy, putting on some makeup and dyeing my hair. I wasn’t afraid of having fun with my gender fluidity and being proud of my feminine way of expression. So by the end of high school, they were calling me ‘Madonna,’ even my teachers [laughs]. It was at the end of high school when I met a guy around my age, and he was my first boyfriend. It was my first sexual experience as well.

When I was 20, I auditioned for Got Talent, and that’s when my career as a singer really started. I sang ‘Paparazzi’ by Lady Gaga and also the French song called ‘Bambino’ by Dalida. It was huge, like six or almost seven million people watched my episode and people went crazy. Not in a good way. Haters were writing things like “who is this fucking guy? Why does he look like a girl? And sing like a girl? He must be a faggot! He doesn’t have talent, it’s all about the looks and controversy”... My god, that was hard to process for a 20-year-old. I think nobody’s ready for that. I had struggles with my mom because somebody made my coming-out to her without my knowledge. Till this day I don’t know who exactly, but someone

did, and she couldn’t process that for years. Someone stole my choice, my privilege, how and when I want to come out. There was also a lot of pressure from the media, society and my family. When I was at the semi-finals, I’ve been really struggling with singing live because it hit me hard that I was going to be seen live by millions, and many of them just hate me. I saw thousands of comments about me which were really, really bad and malicious towards me. They were saying that I’m definitely a pedophile and that I should be killed, and that Hitler knew what he was doing with people like me. Terrible fucking things. It’s impossible to be ready for that kind of reaction.

My latest album, ‘Echo,’ deals with my past, confronting traumas, struggles, and sadness—letting them fade away. It’s about confronting them, shaking their hand, and saying, ‘The past stays in memories; we can only try to reshape them into something beautiful. Even when it hurts’.





MADDOX



ÉCHO



les roses noires
s.e.x.
girl from warsaw streets
dans mon cœur
qrva
one more shot
écho



LUDWIKA

Sexuality is fluid. We spend our whole lives getting to know ourselves, so every day we can feel something new. Sometimes we may be surprised by what we discover. To explore our sexuality, we need a sense of security, which we sometimes lack within ourselves. When your parents are not supportive, emotionally available to you, or encouraging of our individuality, everything slows down or stops completely.

During the transition from childhood to adolescence, many things happen in your body that you do not understand and that feel disturbing and strange. At this time, we need a wise adult with whom you feel safe, someone who can help you realize that nothing is wrong. In Polish homes, this has traditionally been a taboo, sinful topic. Parents often deny this to their children and subconsciously distance themselves from the teenager, feeling anxious about their emerging sexuality, which causes hostility.

As we mature emotionally and become safe adults for ourselves, we connect more deeply with our sexual essence. In Poland, fear and shame surrounding sexuality have been deeply rooted in us for generations. We are all affected by this, but I believe girls are much more impacted.

There were moments in my life when I thought I was asexual. Depression and anxiety denied me the freedom and openness needed for self-exploration. When you struggle with everyday life and the voices in your head, there is no place for such things; it is simply unavailable. Your energy is focused on survival, and sometimes you don't even have the resources for that.









– “While our fantasies often remain in our head, there’s undeniable value in manifesting them and experiencing their reality. And I will continue to do so.”

I must admit that I am very lucky with people. I have made beautiful friendships over the last few years. Moments before moving to Warsaw, I met Marta; it was a deep friendship from our first conversation. These talks convinced me that it was time to move to the capital, a decision that turned out to be life-changing for me. Warsaw’s vibrant mix of people, embracing all sexualities and gender identities (SAGA), along with its rich art and music scenes, greatly broadened my worldview. It was a time for me to bloom and follow this new journey of self-discovery.

Music, rhythm, and dance play a big role in this development, serving as both an expression and exploration of my inner self. As a child, I took some dance classes but never liked the idea of memorizing moves and learning routines. Now, dancing freely allows me to explore and understand myself without constraints. Movement brings me joy and strength, deepening my connection with my body and emotions. Immersing myself in sound, I interpret what I hear with closed eyes, a truly liberating experience. It feels like a new way of making love.

While our fantasies often remain in our head, there’s undeniable value in manifesting them and experiencing their reality. And I will continue to do so.







– “I’ve chosen to live with my grandma, who I like the most. Initially, she preferred to share her apartment with a girl or a straight boy, but over the years, she has come to appreciate me for who I am.”

MACS

I don’t have a great connection with my family. My parents are divorced, and we don’t talk that much. My father, like many from his generation, envisioned me having a traditional family and struggles to cope with me being queer. I told him four years ago, and maybe he needs more time. Meanwhile, I’ve chosen to live with my grandma, who I like the most. She grew up in a very conservative Poland but is now very accepting. Initially, she preferred to share her apartment with a girl or a straight boy, but over the years, she has come to appreciate me for who I am.

I found freedom in Whacking, a dance style from gay communities of color in 1970s LA. When it became popular in Poland, it was mostly straight white girls copying the moves, which lacked queer representation. This made it hard for me to find my place. So, we created our own crew, dressed up, wore makeup, and embraced the history of Whacking and Punking. I came out as gay within the group, and soon others followed. We trained twice a week and felt like a family, creating the freedom Whacking is intended for. This was a big contrast to the conservative dressing even within the queer community, which led to mixed reactions. ▼







- “Conservative media and politicians often claim that “LGBTQ+ philosophy is spreading like a disease,” and some people feel justified in using violence to “protect” against this.”

Change is coming as more people from the Whacking community travel abroad and see the freedom in other communities. People are becoming more open. This mirrors broader Polish society, where people are taught to conform and not stand out. But now, more people are thinking, “I’m going to dress up and wear makeup if I want to.”

This shift is gradually bringing queerness into public spaces, though it still has limits. It’s okay to date and have coffee, but public displays of affection can attract aggression, even in ‘safe areas’ of Warsaw. Recently, I had a frightening experience when a guy aggressively confronted me like he wanted to attack me about my “I love hot dads” scarf. I thought, ‘Fuck this’ and ran away, valuing my safety.

Conservative media and politicians often claim that “LGBT philosophy is spreading like a disease,” and some people feel justified in using violence to “protect” against this. Homophobia isn’t even considered a crime, even in supposed safe zones.

Although more liberal parties are gaining ground, real change is moving at a very slow pace. While I consider Warsaw my home, I’m thinking about moving abroad after my studies, seeking a place where freedom is celebrated and the future feels safer. Amsterdam is definitely high on my list!



STEFA

I identify as trans non-binary. I could sense from a young age that my feelings concerning my gender differed in regards to the normative stance, but it took me a while to be able to put that into words and really understand it. This process of approaching the subject, naming it, and understanding my feelings in relation to a larger social structure has taken a lot of time and still continues today. However, that initial awareness has been with me almost since the beginning.

As queer people in Poland, we are forced to deal with many feelings by ourselves. We are shamed and stigmatized and not encouraged to speak up in many cases, which was also the case for me. Only later, with a better understanding of myself, did I find the courage to open up.

Even the Polish language is very difficult to work with in terms of gender non-conforming people because it requires its users to place themselves in a category every time they speak. For example, each verb is conjugated according to gender, and each object has a gender. Even when speaking about actions unrelated to gender, you are forced to indicate your gender. There is no middle form, as there is in English; it doesn't exist in Polish.

I grew up in between Poland and the UK. I owe a lot of who I am to the diverse experiences that these localities offered. Studying in London gave me a chance to explore new ways of being while my friends in Poland kept me grounded in reality. The pandemic brought me back permanently to Poland. What seemed at first like a return to square one, revealed itself to be an opportunity to reconnect with and re-learn this part of myself. It was during this time that the opportunity arose to study fine art in Warsaw.

I'd never really felt connected to Warsaw before, even though I had a few friends there and knew it's the center of what's happening in Poland. There was a budding queer culture here, but not to the extent that I had encountered abroad, also in terms of rights. So it felt important for me to fight for this and actively contribute by bringing the experiences I gained abroad back to Poland.

I'm part of a queer feminist initiative called Kem, which is active in the Warsaw scene. We try to strengthen the position of minorities by building connections and alliances between communities.











We aim to educate people through experimental and radical education, encouraging them to re-center their bodies, and how they are distanced from them as a means of control. We strive to amplify queer voices, queer narratives, anti-racist narratives, and migrant narratives by bringing different performances and shows to Poland, and hosting various screenings and talks. We also try to activate people politically and engage with local politics, exploring ways to resist our oppression and the oppression of others. It's a collective effort about building connections between people where those connections are often discouraged by the state or other powers.

One of our most iconic events is a club night in Warsaw, called Dragana Bar, where we showcase a queer sound and performance. This way of visibility to others is revolutionary for Poland and has a significant impact on the local scene.

As an artist, I engage a lot in collaboratively designed and enacted performances, such as those for Kem. However, I also have my separate practice, which concerns other issues that interest me. These issues aren't necessarily directly political or directly queer, but indirectly, very much so. Queerness is not manifested merely in non-normative gender expression or sexuality, it is also a site at which

normative orders of form are questioned, and this includes the organization of language, politics, aesthetics and many other areas. One of the main themes of my work is questioning unified subjectivity, ideas of totality, and universal truth, while gesturing towards the multiplicities present in reality rather than any sort of dogmatic unity.

I just submitted my final diploma piece, a performance recorded from eight different perspectives, each symbolizing a different way of seeing. When viewers watch this exhibition, they will encounter eight different interpretations of one event. Which one is the truest, or which one is at the top of the hierarchy as the right way to see, is a central question. I'm always exploring this question and really shaking the foundations of what we think we are sure of.

While Kem thrives with only the 4 of us, balancing collective work with my individual art is for the most part very challenging. Right now I am in Portugal, where KEM was invited by an art gallery in Porto to conduct a three-day workshop. Our collective has been invited internationally, from London to Sweden and the Czech Republic. These invitations abroad however, are only a chance to extend or experiment with formats whose main preoccupation is the strengthening of collective frameworks in Poland, where we are based.



Despite the negative label often attached to Poland, I've rarely felt so warmly welcomed. The love and energy I experienced during the collaboration to create this zine were truly special. Thank you so much to everyone who contributed!

With lots of love, Sander



Pablo Picasso's
Warsaw mermaid, 1948

